son, Susima, who was expected to succeed his father, was very much around, as perhaps was Susima's watchful mother. And there was, above all, the emperor himself who actively disliked Ashoka and would not have taken kindly to such a prediction.

Let us, though, for a moment, stay with the sage who—following unknown to himself in the footsteps of the Buddha—reconfirmed Ashoka's destiny. Why does a sage of the Ajivika order figure as the one who makes this prediction? And who were these ascetics?

A 'vanished Indian religion' is how the doctrine of the Ajivikas was described by A.L. Basham, the pre-eminent authority on this sect, and he says 'vanished' because the religion, unlike other faiths with ancient roots, has no modern adherents.[31] This extinct sect's founder was a religious leader called Makkhali Goshala who lived in the sixth century BCE. It was a time when unorthodox doctrines flourished within a wider climate of religious ferment across North India. Like his contemporaries, Mahavira and the Buddha, Makkhali Goshala has been described as a charismatic preacher and leader. He is known to have created a sect around his beliefs, whose central tenet was an all-embracing doctrine of predestination, one in which human effort had no place.[32] Such rigid determinism was rare among Indian thinkers and preachers in the milieu in which Goshala and his followers flourished. The Ajivikas must certainly have closely interacted with other religious groups. Their relations with the followers of the Buddha were ambivalent, marked by both rivalry and friendship. For one, the Buddha was supposed to have apparently believed that 'in the ninety-one *kalpas* of his previous births', apart from one Ajivika no others had been reborn in heaven.[33] Buddhist monks are also shown as having greatly disliked being mistaken for Ajivikas. This happened, for instance, when they were robbed of their robes and, on entering the city of Sravasti naked, had the citizens wondering who these 'handsome naked Ajvikas' were.[34] At the same time, relations between them were frequently depicted as cordial,